02 | AT YOUR DESK

From observation to action

Use the full ladder to test your thinking before a decision or request.

Rung	What to check
1. Observe facts	What was actually said, done, or recorded?
2. Select information	Which details did I notice or leave out?
3. Add meaning	How am I interpreting those details?
4. Make assumptions	What am I treating as true without checking?
5. Draw conclusions	What judgment am I reaching?
6. Form beliefs	What am I now accepting as true?
7. Take action	How will I respond?

Separate the fact from the story

Known fact	Possible assumption	Useful question
"Please send your recommendation" was the reply.	"They already know the answer and are wasting my time."	"Which decision, facts, and boundaries should my recommendation address?"

Use before deciding or escalating

State the exact decision. Check the current source and who holds the authority. Ask the question that resolves the missing fact. Update your conclusion when new information changes it.

Fact I can verify: _____

Assumption to check: _____

Question and next step: _____

> **A pause is not a delay in required action**
> Use the required urgent route when a safety concern or immediate service risk needs action. Do not wait to complete a worksheet.

Training basis: Decision & Escalation, final Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: Watch the TED-Ed lesson